

THE ILLUSORY FEAR OF SELF

Greetings, my dearest, dearest friends. Blessings for every one of you. Blessed be each and every step on your road to liberation and fulfillment.

Man's greatest joy and freedom is when he can give according to his potential. Conversely, the greatest pain is the result of not giving to life and to others according to one's inherent potential. All other pain and all other frustration derive from this pain of not giving out what is within, just as all other satisfactions and pleasures are contained in the act of giving of one's self to life without restriction. When man does not do this and therefore involves himself in a pattern of compounded pain, it happens out of the fear of meeting himself. In the last analysis, all fears derive from the fear one has of his innermost being -- that part which he does not yet fully know and acknowledge.

As long as an individual keeps a part of himself hidden and secret, he cannot possibly be free. He then must constantly be on guard, and he must pretend. Therefore where man has his distortions, he lives a lie -- a lie he need not live, but does due to his false fear of himself.

There are some individuals who, comparatively quickly, reach the point of meeting that private, hidden part, and in spite of fear, they overcome it, and therefore they evolve as free creatures. There are many more human beings who skirt around this, even those friends who live and work on such a path and are involved with their best outer intent to find themselves -- they nevertheless skirt the issue. Vaguely they hope that the goal can be accomplished without fully tackling every last bit of themselves, exposing all, hiding nothing.

This fear of the self is the basic fear behind the fear of life and even the fear of death. Neither could the fear of others possibly exist if man were free of the fear of himself. Since a number of my friends are progressively approaching, or have already approached, the point where "the big lie" has to be given up and inwardly everything battles to do so, it is exceedingly important at this point to discuss this fear of self -- where it comes from, what it does to man if it is coddled instead of overcome.

Fear of self cannot possibly end up other than in self-alienation. It therefore cheats man of his birthright to be a happy, free, fully living and unfolding, giving and receiving creature. The result is that man gets more and more involved in inverted processes due to which he not only loses contact with his innermost being, but contact also with cause and effect within himself -- and contact with that mechanism within himself which affords him relaxed self-government and therefore a possibility to build up his life in a rewarding, realistic way. When man is alienated from himself because he is as yet unwilling, for better or for worse, to look to and expose himself, he, first of all, comes to a crossroad where he seems to be confronted with one good and one bad

alternative. I have discussed this before in other connections. Let us now look at it again in this context.

When an individual fears himself, this fear amounts to the fact, in one way or another, that he cannot be what he wants to be. What he wants to be is an ideal that he pretends to be, or at least pretends to become. But this ideal is unrealizable and unrealistic because it is an ideal outside of himself, away from himself, as it were. This is apparently the "good" alternative. While the "bad" alternative seems to be that which he is at the moment. But that too is unrealistic because the way he sees or feels it is as exaggerated and distorted as the goal he feels he ought to accomplish. It is not even a question of the goal being unrealistic because it is better than what he could be, or that what he now is is worse than he is, although that also happens to be true. However, it is more frequent that the individual simply distorts; but that which he feels unforgivably bad in himself will no longer appear that way when it is out in the open and he understands cause and effect. At the same time, he will discover negative trends, and he will understand their undesirability as he has never done before, without, however, feeling diminished by this fact. Whenever man is crushed by what he is or fears to be, he has no realistic perception of himself. By the same token, the "good" alternative, investigated closely, is not always as desirable as it seems. This flat, unliving quality constricts both "good" and "bad" alternatives while diminishing reality, limiting scope, and deadening the rich life substance.

The first link in the negative chain reaction following the refusal to look at the whole self, to give up "the inner lie," is a narrow choice between good or bad -- starting with the self, of course, and going on from there, limiting many other aspects of life into the same narrow mold. Almost every other issue turns into an either/or. It requires a decision which is impossible to make because even the "good" is problematic. Since it has always been unreal and unrealistic, it becomes unfeasible, unattainable, impossible -- or even undesirable in its desirability. The whole of life, starting with the self, seems to be divided between a stiff, rigid, unalive "good" and a flatly "bad" alternative. Everything that is undertaken follows this pattern. Not one of these two alternatives can ever be fully satisfactory in which the self feels comfortable and at ease. Both are a strain and both feel distinctly unreal.

The next link in the negative chain reaction following self-alienation is that these apparently good versus bad alternatives turn into two equally undesirable alternatives. We have discussed this too in the past on many different occasions. However, it is important that you see it in this particular sequence. When you feel you are confronted with two equally undesirable alternatives, you are in distortion of truth and beauty. Even the most desirable aspects of life turn sour or hold elements in them you may feel as undesirable although you may also feel that you ought not to feel them as undesirable. You become more and more confused.

A typical and important example of this state is a dichotomy between desire and fulfillment. In health and truth, these two aspects become one even before an individual has attained such unity within himself that desire and fulfillment are one, even while there still exists a separation between these two aspects. The free person, who is not alienated from his real self, feels no problem, no pang, no conflict about either. He who is involved in a self-alienating process and has therefore reached this further link in the negative chain in which all open alternatives seem undesirable, must experience both desire and fulfillment as something negative. Healthy desire is a relaxed expansion, a reaching for ever new possibilities, for expansion and fulfillment. In distortion, it becomes

frustration. Desire and frustration appear the same in the psyche and are therefore, of course, unwelcome. The same fate befalls fulfillment. It turns into satiation, stagnation, a dead-end street whence there is no further way. Hence, the individual fluctuates between the two equally undesirable states of frustration and satiation.

When the self is no longer feared, neither desire nor fulfillment need to be feared, for it will then be known that desire will be fulfilled and fulfillment will not be an end, but a new beginning. Distorted and disconnected from the real self, the outlook must be so negative that it is inconceivable that desire can be fulfilled. Hence, healthy reaching out -- desire -- cannot be embraced, but will be rejected. The person in this state withdraws from desiring. As a compensation, the soul strains in self-willed greed which is a result of the conviction that fulfillment does not exist. Hence, it must be fought for, grasped, strained. When man is convinced that fulfillment is impossible, he cannot dare to desire. When he does not desire freely and openly -- as freely and openly as is possible only when he meets himself equally freely and openly -- frustration is indeed inevitable.

Whenever vestiges of fulfillment occur in this inner state, why do they inevitably turn into satiation? Fulfillment can remain vibrant only when the inner being is open and free, unhidden and unguarded. Then, all cosmic energies vibrate in the eternal now, where there is no end to bliss, where there is continuous growing and unfolding of all universal forces. But when the soul is tightly shut off, or at least partially, it is hardened, rigidified, and therefore those vital energies cannot reach the secret chamber. Hence, every activity has a beginning and an end since the self is felt as finite and not as infinite. In finiteness, fulfillment is a flat, accomplished end and therefore must become a burden. It also appears confusing and futile, leaving the feeling of "what for," the feeling that there is no sense to anything, for even when desires are fulfilled, they turn flat and unattractive.

When the soul is in truth with itself and consequently with the universe, fulfillment is a vibrant, unending, deeply satisfying continuum, never an end. Hence, the desire for fulfillment cannot be feared. In distortion, desire is feared no matter what happens. It is feared when it remains unfulfilled because the frustration hurts the soul. And it is feared when it is fulfilled for the psyche then does not know what to do with it. Hence, both desire and fulfillment are feared and rejected -- always commensurate with the fear man has of his own hidden self.

My dearest friends, I think most of you are able to ascertain that subtle feeling in which you can pinpoint and become aware of how you fear fulfillment because fulfillment is distorted into satiation and therefore is an end -- a dead-end street. You will also be able to ascertain how you constantly fluctuate between the two equally undesirable alternatives: frustration and satiation. Only when you are not alienated from yourself will you live in that vibrant experience of desire never being painful. And therefore desire and fulfillment become one as you become one with yourself.

A further chain reaction of self-alienation, due to the fear of meeting the self, is losing oneself in the illusion that one cannot determine what goes on in the self. It is the frequent phenomenon of believing oneself helpless in the grip of one's feelings, emotions, attitudes, and even thoughts or actions. When you fear that your negative emotions are going to control you, you lose sight of the fact that you have something to say about it. Your passivity and obliviousness to the fact that no act or thought can exist without your readiness and will for either one is the illusion of lack of

self-government. How often do you exclaim, "But I feel thus and thus," as though this were all there is to it and your prevailing feeling makes any way out impossible! You overlook the simple, immediately accessible fact of determining your thought and action, as well as the way you want to feel and react. This need not be superimposition or self-deception. It cannot be when the self is fully met. Since you then know what you really feel, you can determine, you can desire to feel differently.

This desire has its effect. When it comes to the choice of your action, your attitude, for example, to what you find in the hidden chamber of your psyche, you need not even wait for an effect. You have the possibility of immediately determining whether or not you give in to resistance; whether or not you will act destructively; whether or not you choose constructive ways of living, of meeting yourself, of desiring and determining whatever course is open to you. You will then find that it is an illusion to believe that you must go on feeling destructively until something other than yourself liberates you from it. You can be instantly liberated from it by desiring that which is most constructive at this particular moment of your life. But this constructive desire is possible only when you know what you are. As long as you are busy keeping a part of yourself separated and secret, the relevant constructive desire will not even be known. As your own secret part is hazy and vague, so must the relevant desires be at any given moment.

Suppose you find and fear hate or hostility. You are frightened of its force on you and on your actions. Simply state: "I shall fully face these destructive feelings, which will not force me into actions, for I am master over all feelings. I determine actions. I determine what I want to do, think, and feel. I now want to see what is. And I desire and intend to change these emotions into truthful and constructive ones. I choose my attitude to meet these emotions. If I encounter an inner distaste of giving up such destructive feelings, I shall neither deny this inner refusal by repression, nor shall I give in to it. I shall meet this too and not be vanquished by it. I determine truth in myself, and I choose constructive ways." Such determination is the first step back from self-alienation.

These are the mechanics by which immediate self-government becomes available, relaxed, realistic, truthful self-government, and not strained superimposition, denial, self-deception, illusion. It is possible to make this deep inner decision at any moment. But you labor under the illusion that you cannot help feeling as you do, or even thinking and acting as you do. When I say acting, this includes attitudes, such as the determination to remain passively controlled by resistance, by negative emotions. You labor under the illusion that you are at the mercy of what you feel, think, and will, stating it in almost these exact terms. "But this is the way I feel," you say, setting a period after this as though this were all there is to it, and there is nothing further to be done. You wait to feel differently in consequence of some miracle to take place from outside. It does not occur to you that you must first want to feel differently before you can come out of the trap. And if you do not want to feel differently, you must know that you do not want to, instead of deceiving yourself with the pretense that you want to, but cannot. Once you know that you do not want to feel differently, you can find out why you want to remain in a negative, undesirable state.

By denying the truth that you can choose your attitudes, thoughts, and actions, that you are not at their mercy, you lose the greatest power at your disposal, namely self-government. You confuse this, my friends, with a false control you constantly exert over your guards in order to keep the secret part hidden. Every vestige of energy is geared to the activity of controlling your secret.

Thereby you lose control over that part which could determine a fruitful, constructive, expanding life.

The imagined need to keep a part of yourself secret is a result of your not believing in your real self with all of its qualities. Yet, as long as you do not commit yourself wholeheartedly to exposing that which you fear, you cannot convince yourself of that part of your innermost being which is utterly reliable, trustworthy, wise, and good. When you do that, you must find out that there is nothing to fear.

Your fear, first of all, is your doubt and suspicion that there is no reliable, rich facet of your inner being from which you can be nourished, from which you can draw. Therefore you fear that the ultimate in you is that which hates and which has destructive wishes and desires. You begin by hiding it from others but end up hiding it also from yourself. Therefore you lose contact with yourself.

All of you have to comprehend this mechanism thoroughly and discover the means to which you resort in order to make believe that you are honest with yourself all the way so that you let go of the last vestiges of control over the secret in you and meet yourself for what you are. Only then can you get down to the serious business of self and of living. When I say "serious business," I mean this in a very positive sense. I mean this in the sense of discovering the ultimate of yourself, which you do not have to hide once you know it. As long as a part of you remains in hiding, living occurs by proxy, as it were. It is always "as if," it is never whole and real. All goals and fulfillments are, in a sense, make-believe.

This is the great human struggle. It is a struggle for life or death, but it is as illusory as death itself. For no matter how many destructive, undesirable facets you may find in yourself, the fear of them is illusion. And the fear of them builds up more fear, more guilt, more pretense, more neurosis, more loss of healthy control over that in you which can be controlled, namely the decision as to what you desire to think, to feel, to do, to be, the determination of the inner course, the inner direction to take. And since you and life are one and the same -- they cannot be different -- you can fear life only to the exact extent that you fear yourself. You can fear others only to the extent that you fear yourself. You can fear nothing if you do not fear that in you which you keep secret -- secret even from yourself, or half so. The vague feeling of hiding something can easily be determined if one sets out to ascertain it. You jealously defend this secret, and in this defense, you alienate yourself more from the vital live energy and meaningful presence within yourself, which alone can inspire you and guide you to fulfillment. By being enriched in this process, you make yourself uselessly and needlessly unhappy.

You soon come to the point when you must pretend that you do not believe in the existence of that part in you which you have every reason to trust. This, my friends, in a very subtle way, is a pretense because it somehow seems easier to doubt this vital energy than to admit the fear of the secret and to give up the lie of your life. Even if that lie exists only in a small part of your being, it has the pervading effect on you that somehow everything seems a lie -- even that which you happen to be truthful about -- truthful not only with yourself and others, but truthful per se. Your very being alive can only be a truthful phenomenon when there is nothing to hide, when you make the great decision not to be ruled by your negativity, by your fear and cowardice, by your misconceptions and destructiveness, regardless of what emotions, thoughts, and desires you secretly

harbor. If you state and restate the desire to, above all else, give up this inner secret, you meet the whole of you. If this is cultivated day in and day out and you mean it, you cannot feel lost, confused, stagnant, disturbed, or disharmonious with yourself or with others. There will be no anxiety, no befuddlement, no bitter hurt. All this can be avoided only with the simple procedure outlined here -- meeting the whole of yourself without further hiding. To the degree that you were willing to do this in the past, you did experience its effects but you forget it. You allow yourself to be ruled by unreasonable defenses against the truth in you.

Watch your evasions; notice how busy you make yourself with other issues that have nothing to do with this great question; see how you would rather deal with inclement issues even within yourself. You overlook telltale reactions and opportunities for clarification and liberation. You thus do not make use of an important key that shows you the way.

Know that many of you present here have been immediately touched by what I said. Some may even feel that this lecture was exclusively directed at them because it happens to touch their immediate problem. But I speak to everyone here and to those who are not here tonight. Some need it more specifically at this moment, while others are perhaps quite vigorously and favorably involved in the process I recommend here. But this may always fluctuate and change. It is therefore important to remember the simple formula of taking hold of yourself instead of allowing yourself to be controlled by your negativity and thereby compounding fear and guilt and compounding helplessness. For you thereby get more and more away from that point within where it is so easily up to you to change without strain or unnatural exertion of control. Your life could be the most dynamic, rich, and blissful experience imaginable, but you can determine life in this sense only when you do not allow yourself to be a victim of your negativity and your destructiveness. The simple formula of declaring your vigorous intent of not letting this be, of not letting cowardice and fear defeat you, will set those powers in motion which must bring you out of this trap. All your fears must then dissolve like fog in the sun.

My dearest friends, the fear of your negativity and destructiveness is so heavy only because you believe that it is final, that it is a static thing, like a hard and fast object, indissoluble, compact. It seems to have an unchangeable substance. You see, this fear is justified in a way, but differently than you feel. It is justified only as long as you cling to it and allow yourself to be controlled by it. For that length of time, you cannot come out of it. The negativity and destructiveness you fear in yourself is substance and unchangeable only as long as you do not wish to change it; as long as you avoid looking at it in detail from up close; as long as you decide (inwardly and often not quite consciously) to keep a secret department. It is always your choice. As long as you choose to say no to looking at what is and giving up what is destructive, this, as all choices, must be honored. But once you decide for the positive alternative, whatever negative exists in you will no longer feel disastrous because then you know that it is not final. No matter how bad it is, it will not seem so bad because you will get to understand cause and effect. This will make a drastic difference in your inner experience and its climate and will determine the course you take. You are not willing to let go, to give up; therefore the worst is not one-tenth as hard to bear as a tiny imperfection would be when the self keeps it secret and is unwilling to give it up. So what is bad about the secret, hidden self is not the actual measure of badness, if there were such a thing, but the extent of refusal to expose it and to see it and the willingness to let go of it.

The meditation that this is what you intend to do -- face it and give it up -- represents the part of you that is available for self-determination at this moment. From there you will experience that there is nothing to fear, absolutely nothing. And you must finally come face to face with that rich, forever renewed and unchangeably wonderful part in yourself through which you vibrantly live in absolute trust in yourself. Thereby all the limitations of life must dissolve. You will find the world such a wide place with so many possibilities of beautiful experience right here at this moment, and right now. In this new widening of life, there are not two alternatives, one pseudogood and one pseudobad, or two bad ones -- there are many beautiful alternatives. Desirable results are not either this or that; they are all inclusive -- all good can be had in and as reality. There is no fear of fulfillment because it supposedly stagnates, for that happens only when you keep a tight check upon yourself. When you let go and vibrate unchecked in fearless expansion, fulfillment is a state of being in the now that need not be feared as an end. Nor does desire for all the goods in creation need to be feared as a beginning that has no future, a beginning that was hitherto feared as ending either in disappointment or in a precarious fulfillment that one is not up to, one does not know what to do with and how to keep alive. Hence, oneness is established between the outer and the inner you. The struggle between the outer and the inner you is given up when there is no longer a secret to be guarded. Hence, a harmful separation is given up and mended. Consequently, aspects of living will not separate themselves for you, in your experience of them. You will no longer fear the positive result as an unbearable end, nor the negative as a beginning without a future.

Now it is up to you, all of you, to take this final step. Some of you have begun, and to these I say, do not let up. Renew forevermore the intent of unguardedly revealing yourself to yourself, where nothing needs to be hidden, feared, avoided. And to those who still struggle at this point, regardless of how long ago they started this pathwork, I say, try it. Use the meditation I have suggested. Mean it! And when you discover the fear, work on it. Expose it for what it really is. Stop denying it. For only then will you discover that there is nothing to fear, that all your distortions and contortions are in vain and are useless. For being what you really are, right now, even in this most secret chamber, is so much better than what you inflict upon your psyche.

My dearest friends, this lecture can indeed be a key at the moment if you find yourself in a bottleneck. If you are not, it will help to make the phases that are to follow much easier.

Are there any questions?

QUESTION: For the longest time, I had difficulties with meditation. Now that I have overcome some difficulties, the results have been nothing short of miraculous. I would like to ask the question what this miracle is?

ANSWER: The miracle is a law of life, a law that you just discovered. This law is that whatever concept you hold must manifest in your life. The truth of life, the reality of life, is unlimited good. To the extent you can embrace, even questioningly, honestly questioningly, this possibility, to that extent this truth -- in whatever area you conceive it -- must unfold itself to you. This then appears miraculous to the person who has hitherto only embraced negative possibilities and therefore could not experience or see beyond these negative possibilities. The fences are exactly where the possibilities of experience and unfoldment end in one's concept, expectation, and outlook of life. When more possibilities are discovered, the fences recede accordingly. The more scope of blissful, joyful experience the mind can grasp, the more of that must come into being because in

reality it is all there, available in unimaginable abundance. The narrow fences are always a result of personal distortion, of neurotic twists, of destructive emotions.

Man cannot experience more than his concepts of the possibility of experience. If he believes that happiness is impossible, how can he experience happiness? This is as logical as any physical law. For instance, if you move your body from here to there, your body can only be at the spot you have moved it to, not at any different spot. This is no more and no less miraculous than the law of the mind. As far as you can move it, this is where you find yourself with it. If you find yourself in a dingy, narrow little room, you need not remain therein. You cannot convince yourself of this fact unless you walk out of it and discover that there are a lot of nicer places outside this little room. If you resist any attempt to help you out of it on the grounds that maybe there is no other room or space for you, you cannot come out regardless of how long you argue about it. You must make the actual move. This is what you must do with your mind. When you discover the room beyond, that it actually exists, it will appear miraculous. Spiritually, mentally, emotionally, you so often remain in a dingy little hole with no possibility to stretch, to unfold, to experience beauty. When you finally test it and discover the beautiful world outside the room, how safe and satisfying it is, you must experience it as a miracle. You then stretch and stretch your mind to more and more possibilities to unfold and experience good, to give and receive good. That is the miracle of creation, as natural as your moving from one place to another. As long as your limbs are healthy, that possibility is given to you. And if you have allowed your limbs to atrophy too long by the unnecessary incarceration, through exercise and treatment they will heal. This is what you do with your psyche after it has lived too long in a climate of negativity and exclusion; you limit your view and your ideas, and this is the result of your hiding from yourself, the result of the false fear of yourself. Once this is given up, the "miracle" must come to each and every creature in the universe. It is as logical a law as any law you no longer find miraculous. The truth, the reality of creation is that there is unlimited freedom and possibility for experiencing the good. That possibility is given to everyone. The healing of the "limbs" of your psyche to take advantage of just that is the very lecture I just gave: giving up the frantic struggle of the inner secret chamber which you guard. As long as this is the case, you cannot experience the wide open possibilities of living and of your innermost being. To that end, I do help you, and I beg of you, do not overlook it. Do not close your eyes to the fact that you struggle against exposure of the secret part of you. Allow for the fact that this struggle is a useless pain you inflict upon yourself and which you can get rid of today if you so desire!

With these words, I bless all of you, my friends. By these blessings, I mean to give you a greater strength that can help you activate the resources within you which will help you in your efforts. Go on, do not let up in this beautiful, deeply meaningful, and completely rewarding undertaking. Do everything possible in this direction. Realize that whatever area you are most fearful of and unwilling to look at, that is where you need to focus most and where you will feel most rewarded and liberated. The freedom and safety you will experience cannot be conveyed in words. These are not empty promises. Those of you who have experienced the truth of what I say here to some degree, please help those who are momentarily in the latter state. Please do not separate yourself from those of your friends who can help you overcome the hurdle. Do not be too proud, regardless of if they are outwardly not in this work for so long a time or are less knowledgeable. Please help each other. You will not regret it. Much help can thus be exchanged.

Be in peace. Know how wonderful is the peace of truth by not shirking this truth. Be in God!

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The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
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